

Healthy Li-ion

Laptop makes advice users to not constantly keep their laptops plugged to keep battery healthy

Dual-display notebooks

gScreen plans to produce high-end laptops with two 15.4-inch displays that cost approximately 1.5 lakh rupees

13", 15" MacBook Pro Owners Still Plagued with SATA II Issues, and can only avail of speeds up to 1.5 Gbps which equates to SATA 1 performance

Laptop test

is pretty basic we don't figure it'll heat up much anyways. The floating keypad is good with nice feedback and a positive feel to keystrokes but the keypad itself was uneven and in the centre – there was something of a wave. This is probably due to misalignment of the material below the keypad on which it rests. Key spacing is absolutely spot-on. The other three Acer Aspire notebooks share a common design – a nice glossy blue covered lid with matte black on the inside. Quite frankly Acer has upped their game since the last time we tested their notebooks – the current crop of models have good looking, well-finished lids and the floating keypads which although delicate (judging by an incident where a key got detached for no apparent reason) are very comfortable to use. Ergonomics is also very good. The Aspire 5536 and the 5738Z have 15.6-inch LED displays while the Aspire 4736 makes do with a 14-inch display. This also makes its lid feel sturdier i.e. smaller size, less flex. This also means the shortcut buttons



Illustrations: Chaitanya Surpur

DESKTOP REPLACEMENTS BETWEEN RS. 40,001 AND RS. 60,000:

For the upwardly mobile

When one spends more than Rs. 40,000 on a notebook certain things are a given – lasting build quality, faster and more powerful components, good usability as well as reasonable compactness. That's not to say that one should have lower expectations from cheaper notebooks but let's face it – you get exactly what you pay for and a higher price gives the manufacturer more leeway to play with internal components, chassis materials and so on. A generic desktop notebook is generally between 14 and 16 inches in size, anything smaller and it can qualify as an ultra compact. Of course the distinguishing line is thin.

Gateway is a new entrant to our market courtesy Acer who acquired Gateway and all its assets. Their NV48 and ID 5801 are two very

and the dark grey colour along with the graphics on the lid looks neat. Sadly their trackpads are some of the worst you will come across – poor feedback, poor tracking and the dimples on the surface are abrasive to the pads of ones fingers. It was good to see every notebook in this category with a healthy 320 GB of storage – plenty of space. We were

also pleased to see at least three USB ports on all

notebook, some had as many as four – plenty of connectivity options for add-on peripherals. As

expected only the Acer Aspire 5536 makes a splash in any of the graphics tests with its ATi Radeon video solution. The Aspire 5810T loses out here. It's combination

of integrated graphics and a Core 2 Solo U3500 CPU is not enough for it to

handle many multimedia heavy tasks and we see it lagging in the video encoding test where all the other dual core options outshine it. It does have an ace up its sleeve however, when it comes to the battery test – a 15.6-inch display that can play videos for 273 minutes is pretty much unheard of in this price segment – obviously power consumption figures are very low, especially since its sleekness belies a large battery pack.

When it comes to bang for buck, however, nobody could hold a candle to the Acer Aspire 5738Z, its great combination of performance, features and battery backup means it wins our Digit Best Buy award in this category. If you're looking for a powerful notebook with a good mix of features we reckon the 5738Z is a great deal at Rs. 30,999. If you're looking for something really attractive looking and sleek for under Rs. 40,000 check out the Aspire 5810T – at Rs. 38,401 it's stylish enough to make an impression in any company. If you want something for playing HD movies without skipping a beat look at the Acer Aspire 5536 – not only is it the cheapest notebook in our test (Rs. 29,099) but its Radeon HD 3200 solution packs a decent punch.



Acer Aspire 5738Z

placed above the keypad of the two larger models is now placed on the right side of the keypad on the Aspire 4736. The Aspire 4736 also has a good CPU although all notebooks other than the Acer Aspire 5536 (Radeon 3200) lack a dedicated graphics solution.

ASUS' K40IJ and K50IJ sport identical lid finishes



Acer Aspire 5810T



Acer Aspire 5738G

different beasts – one is built on traditional compact lines meant as a generic desktop replacement while the ID5801 comes across as a notebook for the multimedia fan; that is other than the gamer. The NV48 is built well looks good with a nice steel-grey coloured lid with a glossy finish but is slightly heavy. Inside the keypad is good and has nice feedback while being well laid out. Gateway did a splendid job on the trackpad – just the right mix of feedback and grip or rather slip – great tracking –